horse riding with nothing else to do but think about a decision that's ahead of you.

During those first months after we left Sacramento, I spent a lot of time on Little Man riding around the ranch thinking about the future.

My health was excellent and even though I was nearly sixty-five, I didn't feel old and I never gave a thought to retiring. I was getting more requests than ever to speak. Nancy was busy with her Foster Grandparents Program; I had a newspaper column and regular radio spot that gave me a chance to continue speaking out about things that concerned me. We had our home in Pacific Palisades; we could see the children often; we were looking forward to fixing up the ranch and spending more time there.

I think we would have been content to spend the rest of our lives that way.

Yet, hardly a day passed when someone didn't call and ask me to make a run for the Republican presidential nomination in 1976. These weren't only calls from people in California, but from people all over the country—people I'd met over the years on the speech circuit.

Eight years earlier, I'd been dragged kicking and screaming into politics. But now my opinion about holding public office was different.

I didn't automatically turn a deaf ear to the appeals I was receiving. I had changed, probably, I think, because when I'd been governor I'd felt the excitement and satisfaction that comes from being able to bring about change, not just talk about it.

It had been thrilling and fun and I was proud of what we had accomplished. Yet, the longer I had been governor, the more I realized the biggest problems we had regarding big government had to be solved in Washington, which was gradually but inexorably taking power from the states.